Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation (CPR)

Cardiopulmonary resuscitation, abbreviated CPR, is a first-aid technique used when a person is no longer breathing or the heart has stopped beating. It helps to maintain the circulation of blood and oxygen to the brain and vital organs until the medical teams arrive.

Quick intervention is essential, because every minute without oxygen can lead to serious brain damage.

When CPR is necessary

CPR must be applied when a person is unconscious and is not breathing normally. These situations may arise as a result of cardiac arrest, drowning, electrocution, an accident or other medical emergencies. Recognising these signs quickly is very important in order to begin the intervention in time.

The basic steps

The first thing to do is to check the condition of the victim. If they do not respond, breathing must be checked. If they are not breathing, or are breathing abnormally, the emergency number 112 must be called immediately.

The person must be placed on their back, on a hard surface. Chest compressions are then started, with the palms placed one on top of the other in the centre of the chest.

The compressions must be performed with straight arms, pressing firmly and rhythmically. The recommended rate is approximately 100–120 compressions per minute.

Rescue breaths

If the person providing help knows the technique, after every 30 compressions 2 rescue breaths can be given. To do this, the victim's head is tilted slightly back and air is blown into the mouth, making sure that the chest rises. If rescue breaths cannot be performed, chest compressions must be continued without interruption.

Continuing the intervention

Resuscitation must be continued until the medical teams arrive or until the victim begins to breathe. It is important not to interrupt the compressions unless absolutely necessary. Even a simple intervention can keep the victim alive until specialised help arrives.

The importance of CPR

CPR is one of the most important first-aid techniques. When applied correctly and in time, it can double or even triple the chances of survival of a person in cardio-respiratory arrest. For this reason, it is important for every person to know these basic notions.